

took a fascination for the sport.

"She was really young, but she wouldn't let anyone else play on the court until she first got a game. And at that age, we all indulged her," recalls Devender.

He soon realised, though, that Anmol's interest in the sport wasn't a passing one.

"There's a saying in Hindi: *pooth ke paon palne me dikh jate hain* (A person's future can be determined by their present actions). I looked around for coaching classes to put her in. There might have been a hundred kids along with her, but her first coach told her after a few sessions that she would go further than all of them," recalls Devender.

It wasn't obvious right away, in terms of results, that Anmol would go as far as she did. At her first State championships, she got to the finals, but she lost in the quarterfinals of her first Under-13 nationals the same year. The next year, she lost at the U-15 nationals to then Indian No. 1 Samayara Panwar. The results did not worry her or her father.

"At that time, she was really very young. She was competing against girls who were two years and older than her. But despite losing, she never got disheartened. I'd always see her smiling. She'd make friends and get along with girls from all the other States. After a tournament, I'd be looking to take her home, and I'd find her chatting with some opponent or another," he says.

Anmol would get her breakthrough season towards the end of 2021, when she finally became the U-15 champion. "That was when she actually started hitting her growing years. She was always very quick, but she was finally able to reach shuttles that she otherwise wasn't able to," says Devender.

It was right about then that

Anmol started getting serious about her training.

"Although she was very good at studies, she decided to take a non-science stream. She also shifted her training centre," says Devender.

Anmol now trains in Noida under coach Kusum Singh, once a contemporary of Saina Nehwal. Her mother, Rajbala, makes the three-hour round trip with her every day from their home in Faridabad. Her training, though, isn't restricted solely to badminton.

"We are from Haryana, so we have some traditional ways of preparing her. She drinks a lot of milk and eats halwa and bajra roti for strength. But we also have some methods that people can say are different. Every day in the morning, Anmol wakes up at 5 a.m. and heads to a park where a former international boxer takes a physical training class. She's one of about 40 kids, but she's the only badminton player. The idea was her mother's because she felt Anmol needed to have that kind of power in her game," says Devender.

It's unusual, but there's no doubt it has worked. If her coach once competed against Nehwal, Anmol, who idolises her fellow statemate, emulated her feat by winning the national championships last year.

Despite being the national champion, Anmol admits she felt nervous when she was included in the Indian team for the Asian Team Championships.

"I was a little nervous because everyone on the team was older than me. And I was getting a chance to play alongside P.V. Sindhu. The boys team was also with us, and you have players who are world number 1 with them. The first time I met everyone, I was just really quiet because I was so nervous. But everyone was really friendly.



Everyone welcomed me," she says.

Indeed, Anmol says her being a rookie turned out to be an advantage. "Everyone pampered me. No one put any pressure on me. Even the coaches looked after me. They would always see if I was eating well and recovering well," she says.

The coaches would look out for her on the court too. "During the match, at every point, Gopi sir was telling me where to get ready, where to stand on the court, and where I could play the shuttle. If I lost a point, he would say, 'The next point is yours'. If the rallies were very long and I was getting tired, he would say that if I was tired, I needed to realise just how tired my opponent would be. He told me not to show any sign that I was tired. At every point, he was telling me what to do and what not to do," she says.

That constant advice and reassurance is what Anmol says helped her play some of the best

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